



Finding Accessible Housing in Red Deer

What exists, who holds the list, and what to do when you are offered somewhere you cannot live safely

If you have been handed the name of one apartment and told that is what there is, this guide is for you. One name from one worker is not the list. It is one name from one worker.

Turning down a place you cannot be safe in is not being difficult. A unit you cannot get into, or cannot be safe in, is not housing. This guide sets out what else exists in Red Deer, who controls each list, and how to get your name on more than one of them at the same time.

Two calls open every other door

Health Link — 811. Ask for a continuing care needs assessment. No referral, no cost, no doctor required to start it. A nurse or case manager assesses what you need. This one call decides whether you qualify for care at home, care on site, or neither, and it produces the written assessment that strengthens every housing application you make afterwards.

Red Deer Housing Authority — 403-343-2177. Ask to start a community housing application and say plainly that you need an accessible unit for medical reasons. Applications are taken in person at Unit 2, 7429 – 50th Avenue, Wednesdays and Thursdays, 9:00 to 11:30 and 1:00 to 3:30.

Make both. Do not wait for one to finish before starting the other.

The number nobody publishes

As of **12 September 2026**, Bridges Community Living, carrying the former Red Deer Housing Authority mandate, listed 309 community housing units across Red Deer, Sylvan Lake and Innisfail on rdha.ab.ca.

On that date it listed no figure for how many of those are wheelchair accessible. Not on the website, not in the strategic plan, not in the audited statements. The words accessible, wheelchair, barrier-free and adapted did not appear on any of them.

That is not unusual. It is the norm. When all 70 of Alberta's housing management bodies were checked on 12 September 2026, **three listed an accessible-unit figure of any kind.** The other 67 listed none.

So when you ask what is available and nobody gives you a straight answer, understand what is happening. In most of this province that number is not being withheld from you. **It is not being counted anywhere you can reach.**

What the two bodies who do publish listed, and where to find it

As of **12 September 2026**, **Calgary Housing Company** listed 140 accessible or adaptable units against 9,941 units on calgaryhousingcompany.org — **a ratio of 1.41 per cent**. Of those 140, 26 were described as adaptable rather than accessible.

As of **12 September 2026**, **Grande Spirit Foundation**, serving the Peace region, listed 17 units under an accessible housing heading against 1,410 units on grandespirit.org — **a ratio of 1.21 per cent**. The Foundation presents this as a program rather than as a share of stock.

Two bodies, opposite ends of Alberta, different sizes, and the figures they listed land in the same place.
Roughly one unit in eighty.

One number that is published for Red Deer. As of 12 September 2026, Bridges Community Living listed over 110 seniors on its current waitlists on bridgescl.ca. The queue is published. The accessible count is not.

These are the figures each body listed on its own site on that date, not figures we calculated or a government total. If a number has changed since, the body's own page is where to check it.

Knowing this does two things for you. It tells you the wait for a modified unit is long, so you apply for that *and* for everything else at the same time rather than waiting in one queue.

And it tells you that when you are offered nothing workable, the shortage is the reason. **It is not you asking for too much.**

The four routes, and who controls each one

These are separate systems with separate front doors. You can be in more than one at once.

1 A wheelchair accessible or modified unit

Barrier-free doorways, roll-in shower, lowered counters.

Who holds it: Red Deer Housing Authority, and Piper Creek Foundation for some seniors buildings.

How: apply to RDHA and state the accessibility need in writing on the application so you are placed for the next accessible unit.

Expect: the longest wait of the four, and no published count of how many exist.

2 A safe unit without stairs

Ground floor or elevator, no modification needed. For many people this is the realistic answer.

Who holds it: RDHA and Bridges Community Living; Piper Creek Foundation for 65+.

How: same application. Write down that you need no stairs, and why.

Expect: the shortest subsidized wait of the four. This is usually the fastest way out of an unsafe place.

3 Housing with care staff on site

Alberta calls these **continuing care homes**. You may still hear the older words — supportive living, DSL, long-term care, nursing home. The law changed on 1 April 2024 and even Alberta Health Services warns that its own pages still carry the old language.

Type B is the former designated supportive living. Alberta describes it as being for people with various levels of medical need who cannot stay safely at home or in a supportive living accommodation. Care staff on site around the clock.

Type A is the former long-term care. A registered nurse on site 24 hours a day, for complex medical needs.

Type B Secure Space is Type B with a secured area, for people who need specialised dementia care.

Who holds it: not the housing authority. Alberta Health Services controls access to publicly funded continuing care. **The door is the 811 assessment.** Private-pay sites can be approached directly, but you pay the full rate.

Cost works differently here: a set accommodation charge, not 30 per cent of income. Subsidy is available on low income. Ask for the financial screening rather than waiting to be offered it.

Do not rule yourself out on the word stable. Some private guides describe Type B as being for people who are medically and physically stable. Alberta's own wording is wider than that. If a private company's checklist says you would not qualify, that is not the test. The assessment is the test.

4 You do not know which one you need

This is the most common position and it is a reasonable one.

Start at 811. The assessment exists to answer this question. You do not have to arrive knowing the answer, and there is no form to fill in first. A nurse or case manager does the assessment.

Have ready: your Alberta Health Care number, your address, and your contact details. That is the whole list.

Age has nothing to do with it. Alberta's own page says any Albertan can receive continuing care services, whatever their age, whatever their diagnosis, and however long they need it. Eligibility rests on an assessment of unmet care needs. A great many disabled adults never ask because they assume this is a seniors' system. It is not.

Your home care worker, a counsellor, or Cosmos Community Support Services in Red Deer can sit with you through it.

What it costs, and what help exists

Rent in subsidized housing

Rent is 30 per cent of gross income, and heat and water are included. You pay electricity.

There is a change people need to know about. Until 1 October 2025 part of an AISH payment was set aside before rent was worked out. That set-aside is gone. All income now counts the same way, which means rent went up for people on AISH living in community housing. The Government's own example showed a rent moving from \$349 to \$570. ADAP is treated the same way.

Two other conditions to know before you apply: you must have lived or worked in the area for the past three months, and assets must be under \$25,000, not counting household furnishings.

Rent Assistance Benefit — for a private rental

This one is portable. It helps with rent in a regular private rental rather than a subsidized building, it is paid to you, and it renews with no cap on the number of renewals. People on AISH and ADAP are eligible. Apply through Red Deer Housing Authority, or call Alberta Supports at 1-877-644-9992.

There is a second, similar-sounding one — the Temporary Rent Assistance Benefit. **You are not eligible for it while on AISH or ADAP.** It is for working households. Knowing that in advance saves a wasted application and a confusing refusal.

Money to modify a home you are already in

The Residential Access Modification Program pays for permanent accessibility work — ramps, stair lifts, wider doors, bathroom changes.

As of 21 August 2026 the grant rose to **\$12,000 per person each benefit year**, and up to \$24,000 over ten years.

Renters qualify, with the landlord signing a property modification agreement. You do not have to own the place.

It can also fund modifications to **a caregiver's home**, not only your own.

You need a rehabilitation professional, such as an occupational therapist, to complete a Modification Recommendation Form. A decision comes within 30 days.

The catch worth knowing: eligibility keys on using a wheelchair, or being a senior using a four-wheel walker, or living with a listed progressive neuro-degenerative disease. If your condition is not on that list, ask your specialist to document how you meet the criteria rather than assuming you are out.

Scale: this program reaches roughly 800 Albertans a year on about \$4.7 million. Apply early in the benefit year.

Care at home, if you would rather stay put

Two routes exist in Red Deer, both starting from the same 811 assessment.

- **Client-Directed Home Care Invoicing.** You pick an approved provider and they bill Alberta Blue Cross directly. Available in Central Alberta. This is the simpler of the two.

- **Self-Managed Care.** AHS gives you the funds and you hire and manage your own workers. You become the employer, with the payroll and scheduling that comes with it. Capped at 263 hours a month or \$4,500.

If you turn down a place that is not safe

This worries people, so here is what is known and what is not.

Alberta's social housing regulation says nothing at all about refusing an offer. The consequences are set by each housing body's own policy, and most of those policies are not published. The clearest published wording in the province, from Civida in Edmonton, removes an applicant only if they refuse twice *without reasonable cause*.

So the thing that protects you is the reason, written down and on file.

Do this the same day you decline something

Put the refusal in writing — email is fine. Give the reason: unsafe location, stairs you cannot manage, a bathroom you cannot use.

Ask them to confirm in writing that the refusal is recorded as being for reasonable cause, and that your place on the list is unaffected.

Ask, in the same message, for a copy of their policy on refused offers.

Keep the reply. If your standing is ever questioned, that message is the answer.

If you are told no, or told nothing

In order. Do not skip to the end, because each step creates the record the next one needs.

- **AHS Patient Relations** — for concerns about home care or an unsuitable option you were offered. They respond within three business days.
- **Office of the Alberta Health Advocates** — helps you navigate and can review conduct against the Alberta Health Charter.
- **Appeals.** A continuing care decision can be appealed, and the window is short. Confirm the deadline on your decision letter the day it arrives. Appeals Secretariat: 780-427-2709, or 310-0000 toll-free.
- **Alberta Ombudsman** — reviews fairness once other routes are used up. 403-297-6185.
- **Your MLA's constituency office** — staff help with stuck provincial files, whoever you vote for. Red Deer-North 403-342-2263. Red Deer-South 403-340-3565.

Contacts, on one page

Health Link	811	Continuing care needs assessment. The first call. No referral needed, no form to fill in, no cost. Any age, any diagnosis.
Red Deer Housing Authority (Bridges Community Living)	403-343-2177 rdha.ab.ca Unit 2, 7429 – 50th Ave	Community housing, accessible units, Rent Assistance Benefit. Apply in person Wed and Thu. Check the address bar — the old reddeerhousingauthority.ca has lapsed and now serves gambling content, and still appears in search under the old name.
Bridges Community Living	bridgescl.ca #202, 4719 – 48 Ave	Self-contained and affordable apartments across Central Alberta.
Piper Creek Foundation	403-343-1077 piper creek.ca	Subsidized seniors apartments, lodges and supportive living.
Alberta Supports	1-877-644-9992	Rent Assistance Benefit, AISH and ADAP questions.
RAMP	alberta.ca/residential-access-modification-program	Up to \$12,000 a year for home modifications. Renters eligible with landlord consent.
Cosmos Community Support Services	403-343-0715 1-7428 49 Ave	Red Deer disability organisation. Will help you navigate and apply.
Find Housing tool	findhousing.alberta.ca	Search subsidized housing providers by community.
211 Alberta	Dial 211	Round-the-clock referral to local services.
AHS Patient Relations	albertahealthservices.ca	Concerns about home care or what you were offered.
Appeals Secretariat	780-427-2709 310-0000 toll-free	Appealing a continuing care decision. Deadlines are short.
Alberta Ombudsman	403-297-6185 ombudsman.ab.ca	Fairness review after other routes are used.

What we could not confirm, said plainly

Wait times are not published for Red Deer community housing or supportive living. The published answer is that position depends on your assessed priority, not on how long you have waited. Anyone who gives you a number is estimating. Ask each provider directly and write down who told you what, and when.

RDHA does not publish its policy on refused offers. The reasonable-cause protection above is drawn from another Alberta housing body's published policy. Get RDHA's own position in writing.

Priority scoring no longer has a disability line. The separate categories for accessibility need and for accommodation harmful to health were repealed in 2022. Need is now captured under broader headings such as health and safety risk. Document the medical need heavily, because there is no longer a box that captures it for you.

Some housing pages still say AISH and have not been updated to name ADAP. If a worker tells you ADAP does not qualify where AISH would, ask them to put that in writing. It is usually the page that is out of date, not the rule.

Being worn down by this is what happens to a person carrying it. It is not evidence that anything is wrong with you.

You are allowed to say a place is not safe. Say it in writing, and keep going.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com

Compiled September 2026 from Alberta Health Services, Alberta.ca, Red Deer Housing Authority and Government of Alberta sources. Verify anything time-sensitive before relying on it.